

"Sir," said DR. JOHNSON, "let us take a walk down Fleet Street."

TEMPLE BAR

A London Magazine

FOR TOWN AND COUNTRY READERS.

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The Kalewala.

BY JOHN OXENFORD.

To a certain class of modern philologists, no poem in the world is more familiar than the Kalewala, the long epic, which is to the mythology and traditional lore of the Finns what the Iliad and Odyssey of Homer are to the heroic story of ancient Greece. It is the source from which nearly all the information connected with the religious creed, the moral notions, the customs, and the domestic details of a most remarkable race is to be obtained. If we would know how the Greeks of the heroic age prayed, fought, eat, drank, sported, and clothed themselves, we turn to the pages of Homer. If we would obtain similar knowledge on the subject of the Finns, we consult the Kalewala.

Though the traditions of the Finnish heroes are possibly as old as those of Achilles and Ajax, the arrangement of them into a continuous poem is a work of very recent date. No Wolfian controversy will arise respecting the construction of the Kalewala, for it is not more than twenty-five years since the Peisistratid who first put together the isolated songs, or Runes, published the result of his labours. Fragments of Finnish poetry, collected from the oral traditions of the people, had already made their appearance, though even the first important collection of these, which was made by Dr. Zacharias Topelius, dates no further back than 1822. An attempt made by Professor Becker, some ten years before, to arrange a few of the songs in consecutive order is just worth mentioning, because it probably suggested to Dr. Lönnrot the notion of making the same experiment on a larger scale. But it is with Dr. Lönnrot that the existence of the epic as an epic, with the title "Kalewala," begins. He published it in thirty-two Runes,—that is to say, books or cantos, for the word, which previously denoted an independent poem, now sinks into little more than a sign of division, though here and there, it must be confessed an abrupt transition occurs, to which a parallel would not be found in the Iliad or the Odyssey. In 1849 a second edition of the Kalewala was published, likewise under the superintendence of Dr. Lönnrot, containing fifty cantos and nearly 23,000 lines. It is this edition that philologists have in view when they quote from the Kalewala, unless they expressly refer to the earlier publication.

Although, as I have said, the Kalewala is familiar to a certain class of philologists, that class is scarcely a drop in that ocean of humanity, the British public. Hence, humbly relying on the assistance of the great Finnish scholars Castrén and Schiefner, I venture to narrate a curious cycle of legends that will be perfectly new to thousands, though the units may accuse me of telling an oft-told tale. In a word, I give the story of the Kalewala.

The poem begins with a cosmogony of the kind which we find in the mythological traditions of many races. An allegorical female, called the Daughter of the Air, finds herself in a fair way to become a mother, through the influence of the wind while she is disporting on the surface of the water; but her expectations are so far from speedily fulfilled, that she floats about for 700 years before she increases, or rather commences, the population. In this condition, she offers a prayer to the supreme deity Ukko; and a duck at last appears, and builds upon her knee, which it takes for a mountain, a nest, in which it lays six golden eggs and a seventh of iron. When the eggs have been sat upon for some time, the Water-Mother (as the maiden is now called) feels a painful sensation of burning, and shakes them off, so that they fall into the water. The shells form the upper and lower vaults of the universe, the yolk becomes the sun, the white is coagulated into the moon, some particles are converted into stars and clouds. Raising her head above the flood, the Water-Mother herself creates the various divisions of the land and sea, a touch of her hand forming promontories, her head hollowing out gulfs, and so on. Thirty more years, however, elapse before she gives birth to the son, who is growing weary of his confinement, and is no other than the hero of the poem, Wäinämöinen. At last, rushing into the world by his own exertion, he plunges headlong into the water, where he remains eight years, and ultimately settles on a barren island.

Remaining several years more on this spot, he grows weary of its unfruitful condition; but is at last comforted by a beneficent deity, who is represented as a slender boy, and bears the two names, Pellerwoinen and Samsa. Pellerwoinen sows and plants liberally, and the bare earth is clothed with vegetation, to the great delight of Wäinämöinen, who is, however, disappointed at the non-appearance of the oak. In a few days the deficiency is supplied: the hay which has been made by five "water-maidens" is set on fire by a giant, who rises from the flood, and an acorn is found among the ashes. The oak that now grows proves a source of mischief; for it is so tall, and its branches are so close and wide, that it arrests the passage of the clouds, and shuts out the light of the sun and moon. Wäinämöinen, greatly shocked, calls on his mother for assistance; and in answer to his invocation a little man appears, no taller than his thumb, and clad entirely in copper. He laughs at the diminutive stature of the apparition, which replies by suddenly growing to a colossal height, and felling the oak with three strokes of an axe. The earth now enjoys the blessing of light; and the fragments of the tree, which are borne in all directions by the waters, endow with miraculous powers those who are so fortunate as to find them.

Wandering about, Wäinämöinen finds on the shore of the "Blue Sea" seven grains, which he is going to sow in a woody district, when he is warned by a bird that his labour will be in vain, if he does not first clear away the forest. He accordingly fells all the trees, with the exception of a single birch, which he leaves as a resting-place for the

birds. This consideration for the feathered tribe pleases the eagle, who has watched the operations of Wäinämöinen, and he kindles a flame which reduces all the trees and the brushwood to ashes. Wäinämöinen now sows the seven seeds, which he has carefully enclosed in skins, at the same time piously addressing the goddess of the earth and the celestial deity Ukko :

“Ancient goddess, who art dwelling
In the depth, the great earth-mother ;
Let the turf put forth its vigour,
Let the soil exert its forces.
For the pow’r in earth that dwelleth
Well I know will never fail me,
If the daughters of creation
With their kind assistance bless me.
Earth, awaken from thy slumber,
Thou domain of the Creator ;
Let the many stalks thou bearest
With a thousand ears grow fruitful,
Through my labour, through my sowing.
For my toil is very heavy.
Ukko, thou great God above me,
Thou, O Father, in the heavens,
Who amid the clouds art dwelling,
And canst guide them at Thy pleasure,
Oh, direct them, in Thy wisdom,
From the north, and from the north-east ;
From the west, too, send them hither,
And before them come the south wind.
Send the rain from Thy high heaven ;
Let the heavy clouds drop heavy,
That the ears may rise in vigour,
That the grain may cheerly rustle.”

Wäinämöinen’s prayer is granted, the seed grows, and spring is upon the earth, heralded by the cuckoo, who, asking why the birch-tree is left, is thus answered by Wäinämöinen :

“Cuckoo, I have left this birch-tree
As a place for pleasant warbling ;
Let thy voice be heard, O cuckoo,
Freely sing from throat melodious,
Sweetly sing with voice of silver,
Sing at morning, sing at evening,
Sing amid the heat of noontide,—
As a blessing to my labour,
That the wood may better flourish,
That the corn may be abundant.”

Wäinämöinen now passes an agreeable life on the plains of Kalewala, singing day and night such sublime songs about the origin of all things, that his fame reaches the ears of Joukahainen, a Lapland youth, who, moved by envy, resolves to defeat him in a vocal contest. In spite of the entreaties of his father and mother, Joukahainen sets off for Kalewala in a magnificent sledge, and in three days meets Wäinämöinen, likewise in a sledge, on the road. The sledges come into collision, and the dispute which ensues resolves itself into a trial of wisdom. Joukahainen

begins by singing various platitudes and trivial facts, which being heard with scorn by Wäinämöinen, he takes a higher tone, and haughtily asserts that he was one of the creators of the universe. Indignant at this falsehood, and contemptuously refusing a challenge to fight with swords, Wäinämöinen sings in his turn, and to such purpose that Joukahainen gradually sinks into the earth, while his sledge and his garments are subjected to the most fantastic transformations. In this predicament, the rash youth attempts to regain his liberty by successively offering to Wäinämöinen a pair of marvellous bows, a couple of useful messengers, two horses, caps full of gold and silver, quantities of corn; but all in vain, as the conqueror asserts he has enough of such possessions already. When, however, Joukahainen at last offers his sister Aino, Wäinämöinen, delighted at the prospect of obtaining so fair a wife, at once releases him, and he goes home in very desponding condition to his parents. His sister is equally grieved at the thought of leaving her father's home; but the old woman, his mother, is rejoiced that she will obtain a son-in-law of such renown.

Aino's dislike of old Wäinämöinen (he is called "old" even before his birth) is increased by some gullant speeches with which he accosts her, while she is gathering branches in a wood for the purpose of making brooms. She runs home in an agony of grief, in which her mother does not at all participate; but, on the contrary, advises her to make herself as smart as possible, and in particular to put on certain golden girdles and blue gowns that were made by the Daughter of the Moon, from whom in her youth she received them as a gift. Aino refuses to be consoled, but puts on the fine clothes, and flies from home to avoid the hateful marriage. On the third day after her flight, while she is lamenting on the sea-shore, and preparing to take a bath, a stone on which she attempts to sit rolls into the water, and she sinks with it, bewailing her own untimely end. Various animals perceive the accident; but neither the bear, the wolf, nor the fox will quit their usual occupations to carry the bad news to her parents. The melancholy office is performed by the hare; and such is the remorseful grief of Aino's mother, who justly regards herself as the cause of her daughter's decease, that she not only weeps so violently as to wet through all her garments, but her tears form three great rivers. In every one of the rivers is a cataract, and in each of these is a hill upon which stands a birch-tree, on the top of which three cuckoos are singing.

As for Wäinämöinen, he no sooner hears the fate of Aino than he resolves to recover her, and calls upon an obscure dreaming deity (a sort of Morpheus), named Untamo, to show the abode of the water-goddesses. A certain woody island is indicated, to which Wäinämöinen at once proceeds in a boat, and commences angling in the ordinary fashion. Soon he hooks the most beautiful fish he has ever seen in his life, and prepares to cut it up with his knife; when it leaps back into the water, and reproaching him for his want of discernment, confesses that it is Joukahainen's sister, who, in altered mood, had come to be his wife, but is now lost to him for ever. Wäinämöinen is overwhelmed with grief, less perhaps at the loss of the

lovely Aino than at the thought of his own stupidity, which he feels is increasing with advancing years. If his mother had been alive, he thinks he would have acted more wisely; and the old lady, hearing his complaints in her grave, advises him to seek consolation* by wooing another maiden in the north.

In conformity with his mother's advice, Wäinämöinen sets off for a village in the northland, but is waylaid by Joukahainen, who still harbours his ancient grudge. Shooting at him with a bow of exquisite workmanship, he twice misses him; but the third arrow wounds Wäinämöinen's horse, and the rider falls, to be carried away by a hurricane into the boundless waters. Joukahainen, dooming his enemy to float unceasingly for eight years, returns exulting to his mother; but she hears him disapprovingly, and tells him that he did an ill deed in shooting Wäinämöinen.

After swimming about several days, Wäinämöinen feels the same uneasiness that might befall any ordinary mortal, pondering with himself whether he is most likely to end his days by hunger or by drowning. He is rescued by an eagle, who, still mindful of his benevolence in leaving the birch-tree intact for the repose of the birds, takes him upon his back. His position, however, is not materially improved, as he is placed by the eagle on a remote northern coast, whence he sees no prospect of returning. A beautiful girl hears his lamentations from the opposite coast, and tells what she has heard to Louhi, the "hostess" of Pohjola, as she is called, who, fetching him in a boat, brings him to her own residence, where she hospitably offers to entertain him with boar's flesh and salmon. With such delights he will have nothing to do, but pathetically demands to be taken back to his own country, Kalewala. Louhi promises to comply with his request, if he will make for her a certain machine, called the Sampo. He answers that he is no smith himself, but undertakes to send an able craftsman, named Ilmarinen; and he is accordingly allowed to depart in a sledge, with the information that the hand of Louhi's daughter will be given to the manufacturer of the Sampo. On his way homeward the maiden of Pohjola is sitting on a rainbow, weaving a web of gold and silver. He invites her to descend into the sledge, and go home with him as his bride, which she refuses to do if he will not perform a number of seemingly impossible tasks—peel skins from a stone, split a horse-hair with a knife, and so on. All these tasks he executes with facility till he comes to the manufacture of a sea-worthy boat without the employment of his hands or feet. An axe, guided by the malignant deity Lempo, wounds him in the foot while he is engaged in his work, and whole fields are covered with the blood which issues from the wound. In order to be healed, he enters the hut of an old man, to whom he describes, in a myth which we pass over with regret, the origin of iron, and its perversion from harmless to mischievous purposes. The blood is stopped by the force of

* This incident is not to be reconciled with the miraculous birth of the sage; but the authenticity of the first Rune is doubtful.—J. O.

his own prayer, and the cure is completed by a salve which is made under the old man's auspices, and the elaborate preparation of which is most minutely described.

Wäinämöinen now resumes his homeward journey, and has no sooner reached the borders of Kalewala than, by the magical power of his song, he causes a pine-tree to spring out of the earth, and makes a moon and the Great Bear rest upon its branches, which are of gold and reach to the sky. When he arrives at his home, he pays a visit to the smith Ilmarinen, and tells him of the promise he has made in his name. The terrified smith declares that he will not go to the fearful land in the north; but his curiosity is aroused when Wäinämöinen tells him of the golden pine-tree; and he not only hastens with him to inspect it, but climbs to its summit, in order to fetch down the moon and stars. Through one of Wäinämöinen's magic songs, a wind now arises, which wafts Ilmarinen to the northern country, where he finds Louhi awaiting his arrival. She orders her daughter to deck herself in the most costly raiment, in honour of the expected bridegroom, whom she entertains liberally, and then explains that the Sampo is to be made of the feather of a swan, a small barley-corn, the wool of a sheep, and the milk of a cow. Ilmarinen declares his willingness to perform the required task, stating that by his hands the vault of heaven was fashioned. From the fire which he lights in his forge proceed a bow, a boat, a cow, and a plough, all of fair appearance but of mischievous properties, as if to typify the abuses of the implements most necessary to civilised life, and they are all cast back into the fire by Ilmarinen. After three days' hard work on the part of the smith and some assistants whom he engages, the Sampo is made, and turns out to be a miraculous mill, which from its three sides grinds forth corn, salt, and money. Louhi is delighted to possess this wondrous machine, and places it in a copper mountain for security; but her daughter refuses to wed the smith, on the plea that she is unwilling to leave her home, and Ilmarinen is sent back unrewarded to Wäinämöinen.

The thread of the narrative is now interrupted by the appearance of a new hero, the wild youth Ahti, also called Lemminkäinen and Kaukomieli, who falls in love with Kyllikki, a beautiful maiden resident at Suuri; and is not to be deterred from paying his court to her by the fact that she has already refused the sons of the sun, the moon, and a star; nor by the warnings of his mother, who represents that the maiden is of too high origin to justify any hope of success, and will only treat him with scorn. He proceeds to Suuri, where he is at first the laughing-stock of all the girls; but he engages himself as a herdsman, and by his proficiency in dancing soon wins the heart of every maiden save Kyllikki, in visiting whom he wears out a hundred boats and as many oars. All other means proving hopeless, he forcibly carries the proud beauty off in his sledge while she is dancing with some young companions. After a slight altercation, however, she consents to become his wife; and he takes her home to his mother, who is overjoyed to receive them.

On their journey the lovers have each made a vow—Ahti that he will never go to war, Kyllikki that she will never participate in a village dance. Ahti piously keeps his vow; but one day, while he is absent fishing, Kyllikki indulges in the prohibited pastime. Informed of the trespass by his sister Ainikki, Ahti resolves to leave Kyllikki, and seek the famous beauty of the North as his bride. Before he departs he throws against the wall the brush with which he has smoothed his hair, and tells his afflicted mother that it will shed drops of blood if any harm befalls him. Fully armed, and firmly confiding in the protection of the god Ukko, he reaches the land of his destination, and surprises an assembly of magicians by stepping into the midst of them unnoticed by their watch-dog. By the power of his song he annihilates them all, except a blind old man, whom he spares on account of his worthlessness and insignificance. He now demands of the hostess of Pohjola, who was among the magicians, the hand of her daughter; but she disdainfully refuses to comply with his request, unless he will catch the elk of the malignant deity, Hiisi, who, learning his danger, makes a living elk of dry wood. The chase of this animal is attended with the greatest difficulty; but Ilmarinen, invoking the aid of the woodland deities, Tapio and his family, overcomes every obstacle, and brings the spoil in safety to the "hostess." Louhi, however, refuses to give up her daughter till Ahti has also bridled Hiisi's horse. This task he likewise performs, with the assistance of the celestial god Ukko, who arrests the flight of the wild steed by a violent hail-storm; but Louhi now orders him to shoot one of the swans on the black river of Tuoni, the ruler of the infernal regions. This third task proves fatal. The blind old man, whose life he spared, sees him approach the river, and avenges his insulting mercy by shooting at him a water-snake, which penetrates his shoulder. Ahti falls into the stream of death, and is hewn to pieces by the son of Tuoni.

The blood that appears on the brush informs Kyllikki and Ahti's mother of the disastrous event. The mother betakes herself to the hostess of Pohjola, who at first professes utter ignorance of Ahti's fate; but ultimately, terrified by the menaces of the mother, confesses that she has sent him after one of Tuoni's swans. Pursuing her investigations, the mother, after inquiring in vain of the trees, the winds, and the moon, at last learns from the sun where the body of the youth is to be found. She accordingly commands the smith Ilmarinen to make for her an enormous rake, and with this implement fishes up the pieces of the corpse from the depths of the infernal river. These she joins together, and with the assistance of Suonetar, the goddess of veins, and of a salve which is brought by a bee from the altar of the Supreme Deity, she restores her son to life and vigour, and takes him safely home.

This episode ended, we return to Wäinämöinen, who is making a boat for another expedition, with the assistance of Pellerwöinen, who fells an oak to supply him with the necessary material. The boat, however, cannot be completed without the knowledge of three magic words; to dis-

cover which Wäinämöinen slaughters various animals, hoping to find them in their brain. His research proving fruitless, he resolves to visit the awful realm of Tuoni, whose daughter, on hearing his story, takes him in a boat across her father's river. The arrival of a living person in the regions of the dead is a marvellous event, and Wäinämöinen is hospitably entertained, and laid to rest in Tuoni's own bed. To prevent his return, three members of Tuoni's family make a large net, which is laid across the river; but the art of Wäinämöinen is superior to such an obstacle, and he slips through the meshes in the form of a worm.

The words, however, are still unknown, and Wäinämöinen is advised by an old shepherd to learn them from the mouth of a sage named Wipunen, to reach whom he must travel on the points of a needle and sword, and the edge of a battle-axe. Ilmarinen makes an iron suit to qualify him for this adventure; and though he finds Wipunen dead, with trees growing out of his remains, he removes these impediments, and wandering about the huge mouth of the corpse, slips down his throat. However, by making his iron raiment into an anvil, and doing smith's work upon it, he so grievously torments Wipunen, that, notwithstanding his defunct condition, he insists, with a torrent of imprecations, on his immediate departure. But Wäinämöinen will not go till the object of his journey is attained; and Wipunen at last sings a wondrous song about the origin of things, in which the desired words are contained. Furnished with these, Wäinämöinen leaves his singular place of sojourn, returns home, finishes his boat, and sets off for Pohjola to try his fortune with the celebrated maiden. As he passes along, he is seen by Ilmarinen's sister Annikki, who asks him whither he is going. He first endeavours to put her off with a series of falsehoods,—a very common practice with Finnish heroes,—but at last confesses the truth; upon which Annikki hastens to her brother, and demanding the manufacture of sundry trinkets as the price of her communication, tells him that Wäinämöinen is endeavouring to steal a march upon him. Accordingly Ilmarinen, thoroughly washing himself, and putting on his best clothes, sets off likewise for Pohjola in a magnificent sledge, and soon overtakes Wäinämöinen. The two old friends agree that they will not quarrel, nor endeavour to carry off the maiden by violence, but fairly leave her to the exercise of her own free will in the choice between them. When they both reach the place of their destination, they are kindly received, and Wäinämöinen, who shows how he has manufactured the required boat from the distaff, would be gladly accepted by Louhi as a son-in-law, while the daughter prefers the young-looking and handsome Ilmarinen.

The persevering smith now makes up his mind that he will not be deprived of his just reward, and tells Louhi that until the maiden is given to him he will not taste another drop of mead. The hostess of Pohjola begins to impose new conditions. In the first place, Ilmarinen must plough a field of snakes; and it is fortunate that he now has an auxiliary in t m that the feat may easily be

performed with a plough of gold and silver, which he accordingly manufactures, likewise making for himself a raiment of iron. When he has done his work, he is ordered by Louhi to bring Tuoni's bears and wolf; and is secretly advised by his beloved to forge the requisite chains upon a stone placed at the junction of three streams. Performing this second task, with the aid of Terkenetar, goddess of mists, who conceals his approach from the animals, he is now enjoined to catch a large fish in Tuoni's river without employing a net. By the council of the girl, he makes an eagle of fire with iron claws, which with some difficulty catches the fish, and only gives the head to Ilmarinen, reserving the body as a prize for itself. Louhi is somewhat dissatisfied at receiving only a part when she expected the whole; but she no longer withholds her consent to the union of Ilmarinen and her daughter; and Wäinämöinen goes home gloomily convinced that he is too old to play the part of a suitor.

Great preparations are now made for the wedding: a bull of colossal dimensions is slaughtered; beer is brewed in vast quantities, the origin of brewing being the subject of a mythical episode, narrated by one of the personages. All that is wanted is a singer; and to supply this deficiency, Louhi invites every possible person, far and near, with the single exception of Ahti, whose turbulent disposition she thinks might work some mischief; and Wäinämöinen takes a conspicuous part in the festival, through his well-known gift of song. Other songs are sung by less distinguished personages, setting forth the duties of the bride and bridegroom in their new life; and the feeling is evidently predominant that maidens act unwisely in quitting the home of their parents to encounter the troubles incident to the married state. At last Ilmarinen leaves the northern country with his beautiful wife, and safely reaches his home, where his mother is anxiously awaiting his return. A magnificent banquet is prepared to celebrate the happy issue of the hazardous wooing, and the chief singer is again the unrivalled Wäinämöinen, who extols the hospitality of the hostess and the worth of the bride and bridegroom. On his way back to his own residence, the sledge of the poet is broken; but he makes for himself a new one, using for the purpose a tool which he fetches from the dark realm of Tuoni.

The daring Lemminkäinen or Ahti now appears once more. Having heard of the wedding-feast at Pohjola, he has resolved, though uninvited, to make one of the party, and sets off, in spite of his mother's warning, for the wondrous country in the north. Three obstacles which he finds on his road he triumphantly overcomes: a fiery eagle is tempted by some feathers of the heath-cock, which he has found on the road, to allow him to pass unmolested; a fiery gulf is crossed by a bridge, which he makes of the ice, produced from the rain sent by Ukko, in answer to his prayers; a ravenous wolf is appeased by some wool which he carries in his pocket; and Pohjola is reached in safety. He finds it guarded by a railing of iron, round which serpents are twining; but he cuts a passage with his knife, and reaches the gateway of the hostess's residence. This is guarded

by innumerable snakes; but he disperses them by singing a myth, in which he describes the origin of their race.

When he joins the banquet, Ahti is received with all the discourtesy that an uninvited guest might expect. He is ordered to sit at the lower end of the table, and neither beer nor provisions are brought for his refreshment. When he remonstrates against this inhospitable treatment, he is regaled with miserable fragments, and with beer of the worst quality, in which, moreover, he discovers snakes and other reptiles. These he fishes out of the can by a regular process of angling, and destroys with his knife; after which he drinks the liquor, and offers to pay hard money for further entertainment. The host of Pohjola (hitherto a much less conspicuous personage than the hostess) answers this proposal by causing a pool of water to appear before the feet of Ahti, who by a counter-spell conjures up a bull, that drains it to the bottom. The host raises a wolf to oppose the bull, and Ahti, on the other hand, evokes a hare to damp the appetite of the wolf; the host sets a dog to hunt the hare, Ahti attempts a diversion with a squirrel, which is attacked by a marten, which is chased by a fox, which is arrested in its progress by a hen, which is confronted with a hawk. Tired of this magical duel, the host at last challenges Ahti to a combat with swords, which is fought outside the banqueting-hall. Ahti strikes off the head of his antagonist, and seeing a row of spikes covered with human skulls, places it on the only one which has been left vacant. To avenge the death of her husband, Louhi, by means of incantations, summons all her people to the spot; but Ahti, who escapes with difficulty, by changing himself into an eagle, returns safe, though in a very sullen mood, to the residence of his mother.

Feeling, however, that he has exposed himself to no small peril by incurring the anger of the northern people, Ahti, by the advice of his mother, leaves his home, and departs in a boat to a secluded spot, taking with him sufficient pork and butter to suffice for two years. As he approaches the place of his destination, he is kindly received by a company of damsels, who tell him that he may hide himself in safety, and are astounded at the power of his song, which causes trees to spring from the ground, and works divers other marvels. Assuring them that he can sing even better under a roof than in the open air, he is conducted to a hall, which he immediately stocks with all sorts of dainties. Pleased with his new quarters, Ahti now leads the life of an Oriental voluptuary, making all the women of the place his mistresses, with the exception of one poor girl, who is deeply mortified by his neglect. In compliance with the earnest solicitations of this slighted beauty, he proceeds by night to her residence, and as he passes through a number of villages, perceives that all the men are armed for his destruction, his mode of life having proved less agreeable to the male than to the female part of the population. It is clear that he must at once quit his pleasant abode; and as his boat is reduced to ashes, he manufactures a new one out of a very

scanty supply of wood, and takes leave with many tears of his countless mistresses, whose grief is fully equal to his own. A storm that arises on the third day shatters his frail vessel, and he swims to a promontory, where he is received by a hospitable dame, who not only gives him abundant refreshment, but furnishes him with a new boat, in which he at last reaches his own country. But a scene of devastation meets his eye. His residence is destroyed, and his mother is not to be found till after a long search, when he discovers her in a little hut situated in the midst of a forest. She informs him that the desolation he has witnessed is the work of the people of Pohjola, who invaded the country in his absence, and anxiously asks him how he passed his time. He gives a glowing description of the place, and is particularly urgent in making his mother believe that he has had no intercourse with the women.

Going to the spot where he has left his boat, Ahti finds that sensitive vessel bitterly weeping at the inactive existence it is about to endure, and resolves on another expedition against Pohjola, in spite of the renewed remonstrances of his mother. This time, however, he takes with him an old companion in arms, named Tiera, or Kuura, notwithstanding the objections of Tiera's family, who state that he is newly married. On their way to Pohjola their progress is arrested by the spells of Louhi, at whose command the genius of Frost converts the sea into a sheet of ice. Ahti himself is nearly frost-bitten; but he terrifies the genius with his menaces, and at last returns home with Tiera, on horses which, in the plenitude of his grief, he has magically created.

The course of the narrative is now completely interrupted, and a new hero, named Kullerwo, is introduced into the story. Two brothers, Kalerwoinen and Untamoinen, harass each other by sundry petty annoyances, till at last Untamoinen, raising an army, destroys all the people of Kalerwoinen, with the sole exception of his wife, whom he takes home as a captive, and who gives birth to a child in the house of the conqueror. This child, who is called Kullerwo, is extremely precocious, and promises to become the avenger of his father. Attempts are made to exterminate him by drowning, burning, and hanging, but all prove fruitless; and when he is employed in various branches of labour his exertions are only mischievous to his employer, who, hopeless of turning him to any useful account, sells him to the smith Ilmarinen for a few old iron implements, supposed to represent his full value. By his new master, Kullerwo is employed as a herdsman; and the song in which he prays the gods to protect the flocks intrusted to his care may almost be regarded as an independent idyll. However, he soon becomes dissatisfied with the manner in which he is treated, especially when he finds in the middle of a very indifferent loaf a stone so hard that it breaks his knife, a relic of his father. To avenge this wrong, Kullerwo abandons his cattle to the bears and wolves, and making for himself a pipe out of a cow's horn, leads the wild animals to his master's residence. Ilmarinen's wife, who thinks the cattle have returned home, and goes out to milk them, is torn to pieces by a wolf

and a bear. Such is the miserable end of the northern beauty, for whose sake so many toils have been undertaken, and who may be considered the Helen of Finnish legend. Kullerwo then wanders about the world bewailing his forlorn condition, and resolves that his next exploit shall be an attack on his uncle Untamoinen; when he meets an old woman who informs him that both his parents, together with his two sisters, are living in a small hut situated on a remote promontory of land. The information is correct, and he lives for some time with his father and mother; but being found incompetent in any department of labour, he is at last sent out in a sledge to pay certain dues in a remote part. On his road he makes the acquaintance of a girl, whom he seduces, and who turns out to be his own sister. She drowns herself on making this horrible discovery; and he returns to his parents in an agony of despair, only dissuaded from suicide by the solicitations of his mother. He now resumes his project of making war upon Untamoinen, and takes leave of his family amid the tears of his mother and the revilings of his father and the rest, which he repays with interest. Before he has proceeded far, he learns from successive messengers that the whole family is dead. At the sudden decease of his mother he is greatly shocked, while on learning the fate of the others he expresses unmitigated scorn. With a magic sword, which he finds on his road, after addressing a prayer to Ukko, he exterminates the people of Untamoinen, and returns to his desolate home. At last, weary of his existence, he kills himself with his sword on the very spot which has witnessed the dishonour of his sister.

We are glad to reach the end of this disagreeable episode, and to return to our old friend Ilmarinen, who is plunged into grief through the loss of his wife. To console himself, he attempts to make a new spouse of gold and silver. First he produces a sheep, then a foal, and ultimately a beautiful girl, whom, however, he can but half animate, and consequently bears as a gift to the wise Wäinämöinen, who will have nothing to do with a golden maiden, expressing his refusal in terms which seem intended to point a moral against avarice. Ilmarinen now betakes himself to Pohjola to woo the second daughter of the hostess. As the unhappy result of his first marriage causes him to be unfavourably received, he forcibly carries off the girl in his sledge; and, finding that, while he was asleep on his way home, she has shown herself more gracious to another admirer, changes her into a sea-mew. To Wäinämöinen, whom he meets shortly afterwards, and who asks him news about Pohjola, he answers that the land is in a prosperous condition through the beneficial operation of the Sampo. The old sage proposes that they shall set off at once to Pohjola to take possession of the invaluable machine; and accordingly Ilmarinen manufactures a new sword, and they find a horse, which takes them to the sea-shore. Here they find a boat which is mourning its inactive existence, and is not only launched but provided with a male and female crew, by virtue of the song of Wäinämöinen. However, in spite of all the exertions of the mariners, it will not move onwards till Ilmarinen

himself puts his hand to the oar, when it proceeds merrily along, Wäinämöinen performing the duty of steersman. As they are passing a desolate promontory, they are hailed by Ahti, who is almost starving, and whose request to join the expedition is immediately granted. Praying to the gods for assistance, they pass in safety over a dangerous waterfall, but soon find their course impeded by an unknown obstacle, which proves on examination by the sharp eyes of Ahti to be a pike, in whose shoulder the boat is stuck fast. Ahti, who endeavours to cut a passage, tumbles into the water, whence he is rescued by Ilmarinen, who, in making a similar experiment, breaks his sword against the fish. Wäinämöinen, more successful, thrusts his sword into the throat of the pike, and lifts it out of the water; when it falls to pieces, the tail sinking to the bottom and the head remaining in the boat. This is cooked by the girls in the boat; and Wäinämöinen makes of the jaw a harp, which they take with them to Pohjola. No one can play this instrument with efficacy but the sage himself, who charms gods, men, beasts, birds, and fishes with the beauty of his song; and weeping at his own music, sheds innumerable tears, which, collected by a blue duck, are at once converted into pearls. On their arrival at Pohjola, they enter the well-known hall, and propose to the hostess a division of the Sampo. She rejects the proposal, affirming that the machine is indivisible, whereupon Wäinämöinen unreservedly declares his intention to take it entire. Louhi summons her armed men to destroy the intruders; but they are all lulled to sleep by the song of Wäinämöinen, and their slumbers are prolonged by the "arrows of sleep," which the sage carries in his pocket. The party next approach the copper mountain in which the precious Sampo is kept, and the door is loosened by the song of Wäinämöinen; while, to prevent unseemly creaking, the hinges are greased by Ilmarinen, who effects an access to the treasure. Ahti is appointed to take the Sampo; and it is at last removed with the assistance of a strong bull, who ploughs away the roots that fastened it to the ground, when it is conveyed in safety to the boat. On their way home with their prize, Ahti presses Wäinämöinen to sing, and being met with a constant refusal, begins to sing himself, whereby he so greatly terrifies a stork, that the bird flies to Pohjola, and with its violent shrieks awakens Louhi and all her sleeping heroes. The old lady, highly enraged at the loss of the Sampo, implores the aid of the goddess of mists, who embarrasses the travellers with a thick fog, through which, however, Wäinämöinen cuts a way with his sword. The boat is now nearly capsize by Iku-Turso, a water-deity, at the instance of Louhi; but his head is seen above the waves by Wäinämöinen, who immediately seizes him, and only releases him on the solemn promise that he will never again make his appearance. A violent storm is the next peril; but this is stayed by the prayers of the heroes, who, however, are much afflicted by the loss of Wäinämöinen's harp, which falls overboard, and becomes the prey of the chief water-deity.

Not content with this indirect mode of warfare, Louhi now equips a

vessel filled with warriors, which gives chase to Wäinämöinen and his companions. The old sage stops the progress of the enemy by flinging into the sea a splinter of flint and a scrap of tinder, which are at once converted into a large reef, against which the Poljola vessel strikes. Louhi herself now rushes into the midst of the engagement, assuming the form of a gigantic eagle, and bearing all her warriors, whom she rescues from the wreck, upon her wings and tail. On seeing the approach of this terrible bird, Wäinämöinen again proposes a division of the Sampo, which is again refused; and a sharp conflict now ensues, in the course of which all the warriors are shaken from the wings and tail of the eagle, who, with the single claw that is left her, snatches up the Sampo. It falls to pieces; and the larger fragments sink to the bottom of the sea, where they form the treasure of the water-god, while the smaller float ashore, to the delight of Wäinämöinen, who predicts that they will bring a blessing to Finland. To the enraged Louhi, who threatens to shut up the sun and moon in a rock, and to spoil Wäinämöinen's harvest by wild-beasts and inclement weather, he answers in a tone of pious confidence:

"If I trust in my Creator,
If I build upon the highest,
From the foe He will preserve me,
From the evil one my corn-field,
That the seed he may not injure,
That the growing ears he spoil not.
Oh, thou hostess of Poljola,
Hide the wicked in thy mountain;
But the sun, the blessed moonlight,
Ne'er by thee shall be imprisoned."

Louhi feels that her power has gone, and she returns home disconsolate, with nothing but the cover of the Sampo. Wäinämöinen, on the other hand, collects the particles which have floated ashore, and places them on a woody island, that they may produce rye and barley, the former for bread, the latter for beer.

Having brought this adventure to a happy issue, Wäinämöinen now feels the want of his harp; and having persuaded Ilmarinen to make for him a long rake, sets out in a boat and rakes the whole sea, in the hope of finding the instrument. His search proving fruitless, he makes for himself a new harp of a birch-tree, which he strings with the hair of a lovely girl, and once more sings a song which entrances every living creature.

In the mean while Louhi, hearing of the prosperity of Wäinämöinen, is consumed with envy, and resolves, if she can, to work more mischief. The arrival at her house of Loviatar, the youngest and worst daughter of the infernal god Tuoni, provides her with new weapons; for her horrible guest gives birth to nine sons, who are so many personified diseases. These are despatched to molest the people of Kalewala; but the sick persons are healed by the medicines and prayers of the sage, who especially addresses himself to another daughter of Tuoni, called the "daughter of pain," imploring her to put all the maladies into a vessel, bear them to the top

of a mountain, and after boiling them in a small kettle, to thrust them through a chink in the mountain side. The implacable Louhi next sends the bear to devastate the flocks of Kalewala; but Wäinämöinen, favoured by the sylvan deity Tapio, captures the animal while it is sleeping in a wood, and taking it home, skins and eats it with great solemnity. It is worthy of observation that the bear, while treated as an enemy, is accosted with all the terms of endearment that might be addressed to a favourite child, were it not for the expressions of veneration that are mingled with the blandishments, as this marks the very equivocal position which is held by the animal in the Finnish mythology.

Indulging in the exercise of his musical talent, Wäinämöinen, on one occasion, plays so beautifully on his harp, that the sun and moon come down and settle on two lofty trees; thus enabling Louhi to fulfil her most singular threat, for she carries off both the luminaries to Pohjola, and encloses them in a rock. Not only is Kalewala thus plunged into utter darkness, but the supreme god, Ukko, is himself embarrassed by the unwonted gloom. To remedy the deficiency, he kindles a fire, a spark of which he puts into a purse embroidered with gold, which he shuts up in a silver box. This is given to a maiden, who is enjoined to shake it until a sufficient flame is produced for the creation of a new sun and moon. The clumsy girl heedlessly allows the spark to escape, and it descends to earth with a tremendous crash, attracting the attention of Wäinämöinen, who sets off with Ilmarinen to ascertain whence the new light issues. Coming to the bank of a river, they proceed in a boat which Ilmarinen furnishes on the spot, and are met by Ilmatar, the "daughter of air," who informs them that the fallen spark, after doing a great deal of mischief, at last fell into the water, where it was swallowed by a fish of the salmon kind. The salmon was tortured by pain till it was swallowed in its turn by a salmon-trout, to whom all the pain was transferred; a pike, who swallowed the salmon-trout, is the last on the list of sufferers.

The capture of the pike is now resolved upon, and Wäinämöinen, after vainly using a net woven of bast, learns from the conversation of the fishes with each other that nothing but flax will answer the purpose. This is not easily to be obtained. The roots of two trees are pulled up, and the required seed, found in the vicinity of a terrible reptile, called "Tuoni's worm," is sown among the ashes of a boat that has been destroyed by fire. It thrives well; and the net is at last made by Wäinämöinen's people. After many fruitless attempts the fish is taken, with the assistance of a little man, who rises out of the waves, in answer to a prayer addressed to the marine deities. When the prey is carried on shore, Wäinämöinen hesitates about touching it with an unarmed hand; but the "son of the sun," who overhears his misgivings, states his readiness to do all that is required, if he is furnished with a knife. No sooner has he spoken the words than a knife falls from heaven, which the "son of the sun" dextrously uses, extricating the salmon-trout from the body of the pike, and the salmon from the body of the salmon-trout. In a ball of thread,

which is found inside the salmon, the spark is discovered, and almost immediately escapes, singeing the beard of Wäinämöinen, more seriously burning Ilmarinen, and laying waste the country wherever it goes. However, it is again found near the root of a tree by Wäinämöinen, who this time takes it safely home in a copper vessel, so that Kalewala is no longer without fire.

However, the people are still in great distress through the loss of the sun and moon; and Ilmarinen, yielding to their supplications, at last makes a new moon of gold, and a new sun of silver. [It may be remarked, that the Finns, in this respect contrary to other nations, seem invariably to associate silver with the sun, and gold with the moon.] The manufactured luminaries, placed each on the summit of a tall tree, do not give the desired light; and Wäinämöinen fancies that no good can be done till they have ascertained the place in which the real sun and moon are concealed. By a process of divination, accompanied by prayer to the Creator, he learns that they are concealed in the copper mountain of Pohjola, and pays another visit to that country, changing himself into a fish when he comes to a river that stops his progress, and finds that there is not a boat at hand to carry him over. A party of warriors, who, fully armed, are prepared to receive him in the celebrated hall, he hews to pieces with his sword; and proceeding a little further, comes to a green island, where he finds a block of stone standing on a birch-tree, and supporting a rock, which is furnished with nine strongly-barred doors. Splitting the stone asunder, he perceives a company of snakes drinking beer, and at once destroys them; but finding himself utterly unable to open the doors in the rock, returns home empty-handed, and in a very ill humour, to hear the reproaches of Ahti, because he did not take him as a comrade. However, he applies to Ilmarinen to make for him a dozen keys, and some other implements; and the smith, while he is engaged on his work, is surprised by the appearance of a hawk at his window, who, accosting him in flattering terms, asks the nature of his occupation. He answers that he is forging an iron ring to put about the neck of the hostess of Pohjola; whereupon the bird, who is no other than Louhi in disguise, flies back to the north, and having released the sun and moon, returns to Ilmarinen in the form of a dove, to report what has been done. The smith, going out of doors, perceives the sun and moon shining in the sky, and hastens to communicate the good news to Wäinämöinen, who hears it with infinite delight.

In the last, the fiftieth, Rune we are suddenly introduced to a beautiful maiden, named Mariatta, who is obviously intended for the Virgin Mary. In spite of the injunctions of her father and mother, she refuses either to milk the cows or to ride in a sledge, and prefers to lead her lambs to pasture. The cranberries invite her to pluck them, and one that she is forced to knock off with a stick ascends to her mouth, and goes down her throat. In consequence of this seeming accident, she gives birth to a male child, which, to her great grief, vanishes while she is

fondling it upon her knees. Wandering about, she inquires of sun, moon, and stars where she can find her lost son, and is told that he is the Creator of them all. Through information of the sun, she discovers her darling immersed to the shoulders in a deep marsh, from which she extricates him. He grows up in great beauty; and his mother asks Wirokannas, the person who killed the bull for Ilmarinen's wedding feast, to sprinkle him with water as a blessing. Wirokannas refuses to perform the office without higher authority; and Wiinämöinen, to whom the mother is referred, decides that the child ought to be destroyed. The sage is reproved for his folly by the boy, and Wirokannas performs the office of baptism, pronouncing the child King of Carelia. Wiinämöinen, deeply grieved, sails off in a copper boat, which takes him to a region situated between heaven and earth. His harp he leaves behind him for the delight of his people.

Thus ends the epic of fifty books, written in a metre, which the *Hiawatha* of Professor Longfellow has made familiar to the Anglo-Saxon public, and which closely resembles that of the dialogue in the Spanish plays, save that the ear is never relieved by a pause on a final long syllable. The whole poem flows on in an uninterrupted course of trochees, which, almost painfully monotonous, according to our feelings, is congenial to the Finnish race. So fond is the Finn of a trochee, that if he adopts a monosyllable from another language, he affixes a short termination to bring it to the desired form. "Hat," for instance, he calls "hattu," "sack" he calls "sakki."

The story given above will, I think, be found complete, with the exception of those independent myths which are sometimes told by the personages in the course of the tale, and which, as their omission does not leave any gap in the narrative, I have for brevity's sake merely indicated or entirely passed over. But the peculiarity of which I have given no idea, is the fondness for minute description which characterises the Finnish poet, who in this respect closely approaches Homer, while he stands completely aloof from the bard of the *Nibelungen Lied*, who, absorbed in the contemplation of his heroes and their prowess, has scarcely a word to bestow upon accessories. As an instance of this peculiarity, I give the following description of the manner in which Ilmarinen was equipped by his sister Annikki when he went a-wooing to Pohjola :

"Then she fetched his pliant stockings,
Which his mother once had knitted,
That his shins might be well covered,
That his calves might be enveloped;
Then his shoes, that neatly fitted,—
Dainty boots, which he had purchased,—
Did she put upon the stockings,
Which his mother once had knitted
Then she gave him his blue garment,
'Coloured underneath like leather
On his shirt of finest linen.

Next a coat of coarser texture
 Did she four times wrap around him,
 O'er that garment, blue in colour,
 Which was newest of the newest,
 Next she cast a fur, with buttons,
 With an hundred gay adornments,
 O'er the coat of coarser texture,
 Which a finer cloth encircled.
 Then about his hips his girdle
 Did she bind, with gold embroidered,
 Which her mother's needle work'd once,
 While she helped her in the labour.
 Then the gloves of wondrous pattern,
 Gloves with fingers and gold edges,
 Which the Laplander had fashioned,
 On his well-shaped hands she fitted.
 Then the cap she brought, which trembled
 As it pressed his golden tresses;
 'Twas the cap his father purchased
 When in youth he went a-wooing."

The reader will have no difficulty in understanding how a poem written on this principle can be spun out to any given number of lines. However, it is to this prolixity of description that the Kalewala owes much of its value as a record of the details of Finnish life.

To attempt any conjecture as to the veritable import of the Kalewala, —as to the nucleus of truth, moral, historical, or theological, that would remain if it were stripped of its wild fancies,—would be an act of ridiculous presumption, as the profoundest investigators of the subject are still in the profoundest darkness. There are certain features, however, which may be pointed out, and which may lead the reader to make reflections for his own benefit.

Throughout the whole poem a contest is carried on between the races of Kalewala and Pohjola; the former represented by the three heroes, Wiinämöinen, Ilmarinen, and Ahti, the latter by the witch Louhi. Some interpreters would find in this contest a mythical indication of the antagonism between good and evil. To this ethical solution of the fable Alexander Castrén shrewdly objects, that neither of the contending parties is sufficiently pure in intent or action to stand as the representative of perfect good. He would rather give an historical than a mythical interpretation to the long tale of the wooing of Louhi's daughter. Among the nations to which the story refers, it seems to have been an imperative law that a man could not marry a woman of his own family or clan. He must seek a wife beyond the wide precincts of his kinsfolk; and thus, as nearly all the clans were in a state of hostility, courtship was a matter of no small difficulty, while forcible abduction was in the natural order of things. The constant appearance of the heroes of Kalewala as suitors to the maidens of Pohjola, notwithstanding their detestation of the hostess, is therefore quite consistent with the manners of the people. Castrén is also of opinion that the opposition between Kalewala and Pohjola was sung when the Finns had not yet quitted their Asiatic birth-place. However,

as the poem at present stands, Kalewala may be taken as an equivalent for Finland, while Lapland is represented by Pohjola.

It is worthy of observation, that the martial virtues, which alone command the admiration of most primitive poets, are but lightly esteemed in the Kalewala. The only warrior in heart and soul is Ahti or Lemminkäinen, who always brings trouble on himself and every body else, and is manifestly an inferior being to Wäinämöinen the poet, and Ilmarinen the representative of the useful arts. Most of the battles are fought, not with sword, but with song; and wild as the magical contests may be, they still imply a belief in the superiority of intellectual endowments to the possession of brute force. With all its extravagance, the Kalewala is a wild song of civilisation; and Professor Longfellow imitated not only its metre but its tendency when he wrote *Hiawatha*.

The story of the mysterious machine called the "Sampo" is supposed by Castrén to be of more recent date than that of the wooing. The nature of the Sampo itself is a matter for boundless conjecture. Some regard it as a temple which perpetuates a deity; others look upon it as an ordinary mill. Whatever it is, it brings a blessing on the land in which it is placed, and this is a blessing of peace; the materials of which it is composed,—a swan's feather, a barleycorn, a flock of wool, and a portion of milk,—clearly pointing to the different departments of agricultural employment. Castrén calls attention to the fact, that in the pursuit of the Sampo the three heroes of Kalewala appear no longer as rivals, but as patriots united for the common good of their country. Might I venture to compare this expedition with the voyage of the Argonauts:—Wäinämöinen bears a strong resemblance to Orpheus; the nature of the fleece is not wholly dissimilar to that of the Sampo; Colchis, the land of marvels, has attributes in common with Pohjola.

The sentiment which most prevails throughout the poem is that of maternal affection, which is expressed even by the wicked Louhi, and most of all by the mother of the wild Ahti, who is constantly endeavouring to check her son in his reckless undertakings. However, the marriage state is clearly regarded as one of unhappiness to the wife, and the maid who leaves the home of her parents to dwell with a husband is evidently regarded as an object of commiseration.

The concluding Rune, in which the Virgin Mary is introduced, is obviously of recent invention; but it is nevertheless exceedingly curious, as marking the transition of a people from one religion to another. The gods of Greece were stigmatised as devils by the early fathers of the Church; but the old Finnish mythology is more gently treated. Wäinämöinen is not allowed to ascend to the Christian heaven, when the reign of the Redeemer is proclaimed; but he is still raised above earth, and his harp still remains as a relic of the blessings he conferred upon his race.